

COUNTIF Function in Excel

1. What is COUNTIF?

The COUNTIF function counts how many cells meet one condition. It solves the problem of finding out how many items belong to a group, such as how many employees work in Marketing or how many orders are above 100. A Data Analyst uses it to count records by category, status, or value without filtering the data.

2. Syntax

=COUNTIF(range, criteria)

Argument	Required?	What it accepts
range	Required	The cells Excel checks against the condition (for example B2:B9)
criteria	Required	The condition to match: text ("Marketing"), a number (100), a comparison (">100"), or a cell reference

COUNTIF has no third argument. It counts the cells in range that match the criteria; it does not add or average anything. Comparison operators: > greater, < less, >= greater or equal, <= less or equal, = equal, <> not equal.

3. Simple Example

Count how many employees are in the Marketing department:

	A	B
1	Employee	Department
2	Aisha	Marketing
3	Rahim	Finance
4	Nabila	Analytics
5	Tanvir	Operations
6	Farhan	Marketing
7	Sadia	Finance
8	Rafiq	Marketing
9	Jannat	Analytics
10	Count	3

Formula in B10: =COUNTIF(B2:B9, "Marketing")

Excel checks each cell in B2:B9 and counts the ones equal to "Marketing" (Aisha, Farhan, Rafiq). **Result: 3**

4. Another Example

Count the products with low stock (less than 20 units):

	A	B
1	Product	Stock
2	Mouse	45
3	Keyboard	12
4	Monitor	8
5	Headset	30
6	Webcam	19
7	Cable	60
8	Laptop	5
9	Count (<20)	4

Formula in B9: =COUNTIF(B2:B8, "<20")

Excel checks each stock value and counts those below 20: 12, 8, 19, and 5. The result is how many products meet the condition, not their total. **Result: 4**

5. When to Use It

- Count employees in each department
- Count high-value sales or orders above a certain amount
- Count low-stock items in inventory
- Count customers by city, status, or type
- Count campaign responses, such as how many answered "Yes"

6. Important Things to Remember

- COUNTIF works with **one** condition only. For two or more conditions, use COUNTIFS.
- Text and comparison criteria go inside quotation marks: "Marketing", ">100", "<>Finance". Matching is not case-sensitive.
- The result is a count of matching cells, not a total of their values.
- If no cell meets the condition, COUNTIF returns 0, not an error.
- Wildcards work with text: "Mark*" matches any text starting with Mark. To use a cell value in a comparison, join it: ">"&E1.
- The criteria can be a cell reference, so one formula can be copied for many groups.

7. Common Mistakes

Mistake: Forgetting quotation marks around text or comparison criteria, such as Marketing or >100. **Fix:** Write "Marketing" and ">100".

Mistake: Getting 0 because the text does not match exactly, such as "Marketing " with an extra space or a spelling difference. **Fix:** Clean the data first, or check the unique values in the column.

Mistake: Copying the formula down without locking the range, so it shifts to the wrong rows. **Fix:** Use absolute references, such as \$B\$2:\$B\$9.

Mistake: Trying to count with two conditions in one COUNTIF. **Fix:** Use COUNTIFS when you need to meet more than one condition.

8. Data Analyst Tip

Type each group name in a cell and use it as the criteria, for example =COUNTIF(\$B\$2:\$B\$9, D2), then copy the formula down to build a count by department. Always check your work: the group counts should add up to the number of records. Here 3 + 2 + 2 + 1 = 8 employees. If they do not, a department name is misspelled or missing.